

Betting on God: Pascal's Wager and the Logic of Belief Under Uncertainty

An original lesson plan inspired by **Paul Bartha's** the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on Pascal's Wager. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy or Paul Bartha. Explore the original course: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/pascal-wager/>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12 / Intro College

DURATION

55 minutes

TOPICS

Philosophy of Religion

“If we can't know for certain whether God exists, could it still be rational to bet on belief — and does a decision-theoretic argument really have the power to settle a question about truth?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain the structure of Pascal's Wager as a decision under uncertainty, distinguishing it from an evidential argument for God's existence.
- Apply expected-value reasoning to Pascal's four-outcome payoff matrix and to a "many gods" variant of the matrix to test whether the argument's logic holds up.
- Evaluate the "many gods" objection and the "can belief be chosen" objection, and defend a judgment about which poses the stronger challenge to the wager.

Materials Needed

- Blank 2x2 payoff matrix handout (God exists/does not exist × wager/do not wager)
- A deck of cards or dice for a quick probability warm-up demonstration
- Handout summarizing the major objections: many gods, doxastic voluntarism (can belief be chosen?), and intellectual/moral integrity
- Poster paper, one sheet per small group, for building matrices

Lesson Procedure

Hook: Would You Bet?

7 min

Present a simplified, non-religious scenario first: a one-in-a-million lottery ticket that pays out an enormous, life-changing sum if you win. Ask whether it's worth the small cost of a ticket given the size of the payoff, then reveal that this is structurally the same reasoning Pascal used — except his payoff is described as infinite.

Direct Instruction: Building the Matrix

15 min

Walk through Pascal's argument formally on the board: four possible outcomes (believe/God exists, believe/God doesn't, don't believe/God exists, don't believe/God doesn't), and the claim that if God exists, the payoff for belief is infinite reward while the cost of belief if God doesn't exist is small. Emphasize that Pascal is not arguing God exists — he's arguing that wagering on belief is the rational choice given the stakes, and that habituating yourself into belief (through practice, ritual, and community) is the practical next step even without proof.

Small-Group Objection Workshops

18 min

Assign three groups one objection each: the many gods objection (if the matrix must include every possible god with contrary requirements, the expected-value comparison breaks down), the doxastic voluntarism objection (can belief actually be chosen at will, and does Pascal's proposed remedy of "acting your way into belief" solve this), and the integrity objection (is believing purely for the payoff, rather than for genuine reasons, either possible or admirable — and would an omniscient God even reward it?). Each group builds their objection into the matrix format on their poster.

Whole-Class Debate

10 min

Groups present their objection and its poster. Open the floor for cross-examination: does the many gods objection actually defeat the wager, or does it just mean the calculation needs more rows? Does Pascal's own remedy for the "can't choose belief" problem actually work?

Closure

5 min

Exit ticket: students write their personal verdict on whether Pascal's Wager gives a good practical reason to pursue religious belief, citing the objection they found most or least persuasive.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Does the "many gods" objection show that Pascal's matrix is fatally incomplete, or does it just mean the calculation requires comparing several possible infinite payoffs rather than just one?
- 2 Can belief actually be produced by decision rather than by evidence — and if not, does Pascal's proposed remedy (behave as if you believe, and belief will follow through habit) actually solve the problem, or dodge it?
- 3 If God is omniscient, could God tell the difference between someone who believes for genuine reasons and someone who believes purely for the payoff — and if so, does that undercut the whole wager?
- 4 Does using an infinite payoff break ordinary expected-value reasoning, since multiplying even a tiny probability by infinity still yields an infinite result?
- 5 Is the wager better understood as a stand-alone proof, or as a first step — a reason to expose yourself to religious practice and community rather than a demonstration of God's existence?

Assessment

Students complete a short written response constructing their own version of Pascal's payoff matrix for a non-religious high-stakes decision under uncertainty of their choosing (for example, taking costly precautions against a low-probability, high-impact risk), and explain what the "many options" and "can't just choose to believe/act" objections would say about their version. Grade on correct use of the decision-matrix structure and genuine engagement with at least one objection.

Extension Activity

Have students find and summarize a real historical or contemporary argument that uses "wager"-style reasoning — such as arguments for taking cheap precautions against low-probability, high-stakes risks like pandemics or asteroid impacts — and write a short analysis of whether it holds up better or worse than Pascal's original wager.

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